

Soul and Spirit Taxonomies for Spiritual Formation

A Proposed Framework Complementing Heart Formation in Trusting Scripture

The Setup: Why Three Taxonomies, Why Now

The heart taxonomy established that progressive internalization of trust in scripture — mapped against the five stages of the Affective Taxonomy — gives coaches and disciples a workable framework for setting objectives and assessing progress in heart formation. The test case was narrow by design: a small group bible study, the PROAPT method, trust in scripture as the target affective movement. That narrowness was a feature, not a bug. It made the thesis testable.

But the heart doesn't form in isolation. Willard's (2002) concentric model put spirit at the center, with mind, body, social context, and soul arrayed around it — each dimension influencing and being influenced by the others. The soul, in his account, is the integrating faculty, the entity that holds the whole person together. In a trichotomist framework, which I'm working from here, spirit and soul are genuinely distinct ontological realities, not just functional labels for the same thing. That distinction matters for formation because each dimension has its own developmental logic, its own scriptural vocabulary, and its own relationship to the work of the Holy Spirit.

What follows proposes five-stage developmental taxonomies for both the soul and the spirit, grounded in ESV scripture, built to interlock with the heart taxonomy and with each other, and informed throughout by the conviction — Reformed, Evangelical, Charismatic, and Protestant Mystical all at once — that the Holy Spirit is the actual agent of formation and that the disciple's part is learning to cooperate with what he is already doing.

The Soul Taxonomy: From Natural Life to Spirit-Governed Integration

The Pauline Foundation

Paul's distinction between the psychikos person and the pneumatikos person is the scriptural spine of the soul taxonomy. "The natural person [psychikos] does not accept the things of the Spirit of God, for they are folly to him, and he is not able to understand them because they are spiritually discerned. The spiritual person [pneumatikos] judges all things" (1 Cor. 2:14–15, ESV). The soul (psychē) in Paul is the seat of natural life — the experiencing, feeling,

integrating self that Scripture regularly speaks of as the locus of longing (“My soul longs, yes, faints for the courts of the LORD,” Ps. 84:2, ESV), of suffering (“Why are you cast down, O my soul?” Ps. 42:5, ESV), and of orientation (“Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul,” Matt. 22:37, ESV).

The developmental arc for the soul, in Pauline terms, is the progressive movement from soul-governance — where the natural self sets the agenda for the whole person — toward Spirit-governance, where the soul is brought under the peace and order of God. “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind, that by testing you may discern what is the will of God, what is good and acceptable and perfect” (Rom. 12:2, ESV). The endpoint Paul gestures toward is the peace of God that “surpasses all understanding” guarding “your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus” (Phil. 4:7, ESV) — a state where the soul’s integrating faculty is no longer driven by anxiety, appetite, or self-protection but held in coherence by the Spirit.

The Five Stages

Stage 1 — *Awareness of Soul-Disorder (Recognition)*

The first movement in soul formation is recognizing that the soul is disordered — that its longings are misdirected, its integrating function compromised by sin, and its natural state something less than what it was made for. This is not yet repentance and not yet transformation; it is the threshold of honest self-knowledge that makes transformation possible.

Substage 1.1 — Noticing: The person becomes aware of internal fragmentation — competing desires, unresolvable tensions, the gap between what they profess and what they actually feel. “I do not understand my own actions. For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate” (Rom. 7:15, ESV).

Substage 1.2 — Naming: The person begins to name specific patterns of soul-disorder: anxiety, appetite, resentment, self-sufficiency. The Psalms are the scriptural home for this work — the lament form itself is a school in accurate soul-naming before God (Ps. 42:5–6, ESV).

Substage 1.3 — Locating: The person begins to see that soul-disorder is not merely behavioral but structural — it is the natural life operating without the governance of the Spirit. This is the psychikos condition Paul describes. Recognition is not yet resolution, but it is honest diagnosis.

Connection: *Stage 1 soul work creates the internal pressure that makes Stage 2–3 heart work possible. A person who has not yet named their soul-disorder will have difficulty moving from mere Responding to genuine Valuing in the heart taxonomy — because Valuing requires a personal stake. Soul-disorder recognition is what makes scripture’s claims feel personally urgent rather than abstractly interesting.*

Stage 2 — *Opening to the Spirit (Receptivity)*

The second stage is the movement from honest recognition toward active receptivity to the Spirit's work in the soul — a willingness to be changed at the integrating level, not just at the behavioral surface.

Substage 2.1 — Surrender of Self-Governance: The person begins releasing the soul's natural tendency to manage itself — to control its own emotional states, resolve its own tensions, and secure its own stability. "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding" (Prov. 3:5, ESV).

Substage 2.2 — Petition: The person begins actively asking the Spirit to work in the soul's depths — the kind of groaning Paul describes: "The Spirit himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words" (Rom. 8:26, ESV). The Spirit's present activity in response to prayer is assumed, not merely hoped for.

Substage 2.3 — Attentiveness: The person develops practices of interior attentiveness — learning to notice the Spirit's movement within the soul's experiences. Tozer (1948) called this cultivating the "gaze of the soul" toward God. Stillness, listening, and noticing are spiritual disciplines at this stage.

Connection: *Stage 2 soul receptivity and Stage 3 heart Valuing are mutually dependent. A heart genuinely beginning to commit to scripture's authority (3.3) needs a soul opening to Spirit-governance — otherwise the commitment stays at intellectual conviction without the interior transformation that makes it livable. Conversely, soul receptivity without heart commitment to the Word is vulnerable to spiritual drift.*

Stage 3 — *Spirit-Initiated Transformation (Renewal)*

This is where the soul's actual renewal begins — not as a product of the disciple's effort but as the fruit of the Spirit working in a soul that has become receptive. "We all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. For this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit" (2 Cor. 3:18, ESV).

Substage 3.1 — Affective Reordering: The soul's emotional life begins to shift — not that difficult emotions disappear, but that they are processed through the Spirit's presence rather than the self's resources. "You have turned for me my mourning into dancing" (Ps. 30:11, ESV). Joy, peace, and hope become available in conditions where they were previously inaccessible.

Substage 3.2 — Appetite Reordering: The soul's longings begin to be redirected. The deep appetite for security, significance, and satisfaction previously organized around self-provision begins orienting toward God as its source. "As a deer pants for flowing streams,

so pants my soul for you, O God” (Ps. 42:1, ESV) moves from aspiration to actual experience.

Substage 3.3 — Memory and Narrative Reordering: The soul’s integrating function — how it makes sense of the person’s story — begins to be rewritten. Past wounds and failures are reinterpreted under sovereign grace. “For those who love God all things work together for good” (Rom. 8:28, ESV) becomes a lived conviction, not just a doctrinal affirmation.

Connection: *Stage 3 soul renewal is the stage at which the spirit taxonomy’s Stage 3 (Spirit-empowered fruitfulness) becomes sustainable. A person whose soul is undergoing genuine renewal has the interior stability to bear the weight of deeper union with God.*

Stage 4 — Integrated Coherence (Ordering)

The fourth stage is the progressive integration of all the soul’s functions — emotion, appetite, memory, will, imagination, and relational life — around the Spirit’s governance. The soul’s various faculties are brought into coherent order under God.

Substage 4.1 — Volitional Coherence: The gap between what the person intends and what they do narrows — not because willpower increases but because the soul’s deeper orientations are aligning with the spirit’s direction. “I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me” (Gal. 2:20, ESV).

Substage 4.2 — Relational Coherence: The soul’s social dimension — how it engages with others — comes under the ordering of love. Relational fractures that soul-disorder produces (envy, comparison, manipulation, withdrawal) give way to genuine community. “Let love be genuine. Abhor what is evil; hold fast to what is good” (Rom. 12:9, ESV).

Stage 5 — Spirit-Governed Wholeness (Shalom)

The final stage is what Paul points toward in Phil. 4:7: the soul held in the peace of God that surpasses understanding. Not the absence of suffering — Paul writes Philippians from prison — but the integration of all the soul’s faculties in a stable, Spirit-sustained orientation toward God regardless of circumstances.

Substage 5.1 — Contentment: “I have learned, in whatever situation I am, to be content” (Phil. 4:11, ESV). The soul is no longer driven by its circumstances because its deepest orientation is anchored in God’s character and promises.

Substage 5.2 — Overflowing: A soul in this condition naturally overflows into the lives of others — not as a project but as the natural expression of a person whose integrating faculty is ordered toward love. This is the soul-level analog of the heart taxonomy’s Stage 5 endpoint: a life visibly different because the interior is ordered differently.

The Spirit Taxonomy: From Regeneration to Union

The Theological Foundation

In a trichotomist framework, the human spirit is the deepest faculty of the person — the dimension capable of direct communion with God, the point of contact between the human and the divine. “The Spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God” (Rom. 8:16, ESV). At regeneration, the Holy Spirit indwells the human spirit and begins the work of conforming it to Christ. The developmental arc of the spirit taxonomy is the progressive deepening of that union — from the initial reality of indwelling through increasingly conscious, surrendered, and fruitful participation in the divine life.

The endpoint Paul names is staggering: “that you may be filled with all the fullness of God” (Eph. 3:19, ESV). That is not a metaphor for feeling spiritually encouraged. It is the eschatological horizon of spirit formation — a participation in the divine life that mirrors, in creaturely form, the Son’s relation to the Father. Tozer (1948) called this “the fellowship of the burning heart.” Willard (2002) described it as the spirit becoming progressively transparent to the Spirit. The charismatic tradition insists that this is not merely a future hope but a present experience to be pursued — and the Reformed tradition insists that it is always and only by grace, through the Spirit’s sovereign initiative, tested by the Word.

The Five Stages

Stage 1 — *Indwelling Received (Regeneration and Initial Awareness)*

The starting point is not a human achievement but a divine act: regeneration. The human spirit, dead in trespasses and sin (Eph. 2:1, ESV), is made alive by the Spirit of God. “If the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, he who raised Christ Jesus from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through his Spirit who dwells in you” (Rom. 8:11, ESV).

Substage 1.1 — Regeneration: The Spirit makes the human spirit alive to God. This is not a developmental achievement; it is the precondition for all subsequent development. A person who has not experienced regeneration has not yet entered the spirit taxonomy at all.

Substage 1.2 — Initial Awareness of the Spirit: The newly regenerate person begins to notice the Spirit’s presence — in prayer, in scripture, in worship, in moments of conviction. This is often experienced as a new capacity to perceive spiritual reality that was previously unavailable. “You have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, ‘Abba! Father!’” (Rom. 8:15, ESV).

Substage 1.3 — Desire for More: The initial experience of the Spirit creates appetite for deeper experience. The spirit, once awakened, longs for deeper union. Whether or not one holds a specific “baptism of the Spirit” formulation, the developmental hunger this names is real and should be welcomed.

Connection: *Stage 1 spirit indwelling and Stage 1–2 heart Receiving/Responding are simultaneous in conversion but need not develop at the same rate thereafter. A person can be genuinely regenerate (spirit Stage 1) while remaining at heart Stage 1–2 in relation to scripture. The spirit’s indwelling creates the capacity for heart formation but does not guarantee its pace.*

Stage 2 — *Learning to Follow the Spirit (Cooperation)*

The second stage is the developing discipline of learning to recognize and follow the Spirit’s lead — what Willard (2012) described as the conversational relationship with God. The spirit is indwelt and alive; now the person must learn to live from that reality rather than from the soul’s natural momentum.

Substage 2.1 — Discernment Practice: The person begins developing the capacity to distinguish the Spirit’s promptings from their own thoughts, desires, and other voices. “Test everything; hold fast what is good” (1 Thess. 5:21, ESV). This requires both the Reformed commitment to testing by scripture and charismatic openness to genuine Spirit-movement in the present.

Substage 2.2 — Obedience to Promptings: The person begins acting on what they discern from the Spirit, at personal cost. “Walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh” (Gal. 5:16, ESV). This is effortful, sometimes mistaken, and marked by the tension between spirit and flesh Paul describes in Galatians 5.

Substage 2.3 — Gifts Received and Exercised: The person begins to recognize and exercise spiritual gifts the Spirit distributes for building up the body (1 Cor. 12:7, ESV). The charismatic framework treats this as normative for all believers; the Reformed guardrail insists that gifts are always for service, always tested by their fruit, and never a basis for spiritual pride.

Stage 3 — *Spirit-Empowered Life (Fruitfulness)*

At the third stage, the spirit’s cooperation with the Holy Spirit begins producing visible, consistent fruit — not just in occasional obedience but as the characteristic texture of the person’s life. “The fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control” (Gal. 5:22–23, ESV).

Substage 3.1 — Consistent Fruit: The Spirit’s fruit becomes less episodic and more characteristic. The person is recognizably different — not because they are trying harder but because the Spirit is producing what self-effort never could.

Substage 3.2 — Intercession and Prayer Depth: The person's prayer life deepens from petition-dominant to Spirit-driven intercession aligned with God's own purposes (Rom. 8:26–27, ESV). Foster (1992) called this the prayer of relinquishment: the spirit learning to pray God's will rather than its own preferences.

Substage 3.3 — Spirit-Led Community Life: The person's participation in the body of Christ becomes Spirit-directed rather than preference-directed — serving where the Spirit leads, not where it is comfortable. The spirit at this stage begins functioning as a genuine channel of the Spirit's work to others.

Connection: *Stage 3 spirit fruitfulness and Stage 3 soul renewal are mutually reinforcing. Soul renewal creates the interior stability that allows spirit-empowered fruitfulness to be sustained rather than burning out. Spirit fruitfulness, in turn, provides the experiential confirmation that deepens soul renewal.*

Stage 4 — Deep Union Pursued (Contemplative Depth)

The fourth stage is the movement into what the Protestant Mystical tradition calls contemplative union — a deepening intimacy with God in the spirit that goes beyond cognitive understanding and affective experience into direct spiritual communion.

Substage 4.1 — Contemplative Capacity: The person develops the capacity for sustained interior silence and attentiveness to God. “Be still, and know that I am God” (Ps. 46:10, ESV) moves from aspiration to practice. This requires the discipline of solitude that Foster (1978) identified as a foundational inner discipline.

Substage 4.2 — Dark Night Navigation: The Protestant Mystical tradition describes a stage of spiritual dryness and apparent absence that follows initial consolations. Willard acknowledged this as real: the Spirit withdraws felt experience to develop trust not dependent on feeling. “Though he slay me, I will hope in him” (Job 13:15, ESV). The Reformed guardrail is critical here — this stage is easily misread as spiritual failure or as an invitation to manufacture experience through charismatic excess.

Substage 4.3 — Spirit-Breathed Scripture: Scripture ceases to be primarily a text to be studied and becomes a living voice to be inhabited. “All Scripture is breathed out by God” (2 Tim. 3:16, ESV) — the spirit at Stage 4 experiences that breathed quality directly, not just as doctrine but as encounter. This is where the spirit and heart taxonomies most intimately converge.

Connection: *The heart's full trust in scripture (heart Stages 4–5) is sustained and deepened by the spirit's direct experience of its divine author. Growth in spirit union illuminates scripture for the heart in ways that cognitive study alone cannot.*

Stage 5 — Fullness of God (Union)

The final stage is the eschatological horizon Paul sets in Eph. 3:19 — being “filled with all the fullness of God.” This is not the erasure of the human person in divine substance, but the maximum creaturely participation in the divine life possible in the present age, with its consummation awaiting the resurrection. “We all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another” (2 Cor. 3:18, ESV).

Substage 5.1 — Habitual Communion: The person lives in ongoing, conscious communion with God in the spirit — not a mystical trance state but a settled background awareness of divine presence coloring all of life. Brother Lawrence called it practicing the presence of God; Willard called it the “with-God life.” The charismatic tradition experiences this as the Spirit’s ongoing voice, guidance, and empowerment as the normal texture of daily life.

Substage 5.2 — Conformity to Christ: The person’s spirit is so conformed to the pattern of Christ’s spirit that their characteristic responses — to suffering, to opposition, to need, to opportunity — increasingly reflect Christ’s own pattern. “Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus” (Phil. 2:5, ESV). This is progressive sanctification reaching its maximal expression in this life.

The Three Taxonomies as an Interdependent System

The heart, soul, and spirit taxonomies are not three parallel tracks. They are three dimensions of a single formation process, and growth in each creates conditions for growth in the others while stagnation in any one limits all three.

The heart’s progressive trust in scripture provides the doctrinal and relational anchoring that keeps soul renewal and spirit union from drifting into subjective excess. Without the heart’s deepening trust in the Word, soul renewal can become therapeutic self-improvement and spirit union can become unmoored spiritual experience. The heart is the Reformed guardrail built into the architecture of formation itself.

The soul’s progressive renewal provides the interior stability that makes heart trust livable and spirit union sustainable. A person whose soul is still dominated by anxiety, self-protection, and appetite disorder will have difficulty sustaining Stage 3–5 heart formation — the interior chaos pulls against the commitment. And a spirit reaching toward union with God while the soul remains disordered will experience the charismatic danger: intense spiritual experiences without the integration that makes them formative rather than merely stimulating.

The spirit's deepening union with God is the energy source and ultimate direction of the entire system. Growth in spirit union illuminates scripture for the heart, reorders the soul's affective life, and provides the experiential confirmation that makes all three taxonomies feel worth the effort of the journey. Without the spirit's work, heart formation becomes moralism and soul renewal becomes psychology. The Spirit is the agent; the taxonomies are the map.

Mind and Body as Overflow and Condition

The cognitive and behavioral dimensions — mind and body — are not separate tracks but the natural overflow and necessary condition of inner formation across all three dimensions.

Cognitive formation (the mind's engagement with biblical truth, doctrine, and theological understanding) is both a condition and an overflow of heart, soul, and spirit development. A person cannot trust scripture (heart Stage 3+) without understanding it (mind); but mere understanding without trust is what James calls the faith of demons (Jas. 2:19, ESV). The mind provides the content that the heart internalizes, the soul integrates, and the spirit inhabits. The Cognitive Taxonomy maps the mind's developmental arc; the three inner taxonomies depend on it without being reducible to it.

Behavioral formation (the body's habits, disciplines, and enacted obedience) is, as Willard (1998) argued, both the means and the evidence of inner formation. The spiritual disciplines are bodily practices that create the conditions for the Spirit's work — solitude, fasting, scripture memorization, service. The body enacts what the spirit, soul, and heart have internalized; and the body's practices, in turn, shape what the spirit, soul, and heart become. The Psychomotor Taxonomy maps the body's developmental arc; it is the visible expression of the invisible formation the three inner taxonomies describe.

The integrated picture is a five-dimension formation framework — spirit, heart, soul, mind, and body — where each dimension has its own developmental logic, its own scriptural grounding, its own assessment possibilities, and its own relationship to the others. This paper has proposed the soul and spirit pieces. Testing the interdependencies — both theoretically and empirically — is the natural next step in the research program.

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